

ESL1 Syllabus

English as a Second Language, Level 1 (A1/A2) · Summer 2026

Course	LENG-104 ESL1, English as a Second Language Level 1
Term	Summer 2026, 12-week compressed format
Dates	Tue May 26 through Sat Aug 15
Instructor	Prof. Kramer Gibson
Email	ggibson1@berklee.edu
Course site	kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026

Welcome to ESL1

ESL1 is the first English language course at Berklee. We will spend 12 weeks together building the foundation you need to write, speak, listen, and read in English at the college level. The class is small and the room is friendly. Everyone is here to grow.

Most of our work happens together in class, on paper, in conversation. Canvas is where you submit a few things and where I track attendance. Our public course site at kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026 is where each week's readings and worksheets live.

How you are graded

Your grade is built from five categories. The biggest share rewards showing up and trying. Speaking matters more than writing at this level, because that is where most of your growth will happen.

Category	Weight	What this includes
Attendance & Participation	30%	Coming to class, joining the conversation, sing-alongs, in-class activities
In-Class Completion	25%	Worksheets, field activities, packets, News! Vocabulary! routine, Diplomatic Intervention message
Quizzes	20%	Grammar and vocabulary quizzes through the semester
Speaking Assessments	15%	Intro voice message, weekly Tutoring Reflections, mid-semester check-in, final speaking
Writing Assessments	10%	Final writing assessment in Week 11

Grading scale

A	93-100%	A-	90-92%	B+	87-89%	B	83-86%
B-	80-82%	C+	77-79%	C	73-76%	Below C	under 73%

Weekly tutoring (required)

Every student in a Berklee ESL course meets with a tutor for one hour each week. This is a required part of the program. You will receive more information about your tutoring schedule and your assigned tutor from me in the first week of class.

Five times during the semester (Weeks 3, 5, 7, 9, and 11) you will record a short audio reflection at the end of your tutoring session and submit it to Canvas. That recording is your Tutoring Reflection, and it lives in the Speaking part of your grade.

12-Week Schedule

The schedule below shows the big shape of the course. Specific assignments and due dates live in Canvas and on the course site.

Week	Dates	Focus
1	May 25 - May 31	Welcome to class. Grammar pre-test (no points). Introduce yourself voice message.
2	Jun 1 - Jun 7	Strategies for college English. Past tense. A walk along the Charles.
3	Jun 8 - Jun 14	Singing and listening. Creep (Radiohead).
4	Jun 15 - Jun 21	Singing and listening. Spectre (Radiohead). Two Countries narrative essay (in-class, no points).
5	Jun 22 - Jun 28	Tech reading + passive voice. WhatsApp and Meta packet.
6	Jun 29 - Jul 5	Grammar: simple past vs. present perfect.
7	Jul 6 - Jul 12	Grammar quiz.
8	Jul 13 - Jul 19	Singing: This Feeling (Alabama Shakes). Hidden Theme Podcast project launches.
9	Jul 20 - Jul 26	Podcast planning + vocabulary check.
10	Jul 27 - Aug 2	Podcast due. Diplomatic Intervention message (writing).
11	Aug 3 - Aug 9	Final writing assessment. Review.
12	Aug 10 - Aug 16	Final speaking assessment. Course wrap.

Attendance

Attendance is the foundation of this course. Coming to class on time, every class, is the single biggest thing you can do to grow in English this summer. Each session is worth 25 points in the Attendance category. If you must miss a class, email me before the class meets.

Late work

Late work loses 5% per day and closes after 7 days. If you need an extension, ask before the deadline. I am almost always willing to work with you when you communicate early.

Academic honesty + translanguaging

Write in your own English. You may use your first language to think, plan, and brainstorm. You may use a dictionary. AI writing tools (ChatGPT, Claude, translation apps that rewrite full sentences) are not allowed on graded work, because you are here to grow your English, not the AI's. If you are not sure whether a tool is allowed, ask me.

Materials

All readings, worksheets, and handouts are free and live on the public course site at kramermusician.github.io/esl1-summer-2026. You will also need: a notebook (the MUJI Recycled Paper Notebook 0.3 inch lined B5, available on Newbury Street for about \$2.40), a pencil, and a colored pen for corrections. We will also use Anki for vocabulary practice. Anki is free.

Questions

Email gigibson1@berklee.edu any time. I respond within one business day.

Syllabus version 2026-05-25. Subject to small updates during the semester.